

Emeka's 3rd-Grade Year — *Author, Not Audience*

A Spark Builders curriculum, built for Emeka

For: Emeka (age 8, entering 3rd grade, Fall 2026) · Built by: Dad / Coach Lamont Engine 1 — daily skills: her app, [emeka-grades.vercel.app](#) · Engine 2 — real builds: the Spark loop

Why this curriculum is different

Emeka is a **bright, gifted-track kid with three pinpoint gaps** — and the plan is built around exactly that, not around generic "do 3rd grade."

- Her strong early grades earned her a **NYC Gifted & Talented eligibility letter** — so the *ceiling* is high. She's curious, high-effort, and strong with words out loud.
- But her most recent report card flagged **three specific skills to grow**, and we target them on purpose this year.

She's strong at (keep feeding)	She needs to grow (this year's targets)
Effort & focus · SEL · vocabulary & discussion · PE/Music	Reading comprehension (not decoding — <i>understanding</i>)
Gifted-track potential (G&T eligible)	Writing — adding detail & fixing mechanics
Loves to talk about ideas	Math precision & strategy (right <i>method</i> , not just concept)

So this year does two things at once:

1. **Closes those three gaps** and locks in the 3rd-grade standards she's graded on (report card stays strong → stays G&T-eligible), and
1. **Aims her upward and outward** — she doesn't just *do* school, she ****builds** real things for real people* *using what she's learning*. *That's the Spark idea*: a kid facing outward.* This is what keeps a high-potential kid from coasting.

Good news: the app you built ([emeka-grades](#)) was *already* designed around these three gaps — the Reading section adds a comprehension/retell step, Writing checks detail + mechanics, and Math uses the "what's happening / what do you know / what are you trying to find" strategy scaffold. This curriculum just wraps a full year around it.

The one rule that runs the whole year: Emeka is the **author**, not the audience. She notices the problem, she decides what to make, she directs it. You're the coach who drives — never the one who decides.

Her two problem-solving superpowers (she learns *both* this year)

This is the heart of your question — Spark teaches a kid to handle a problem on **both sides** of the moment it appears:

- 🔭 **See it coming — Foresight.** Spot the **smoke before the fire** and build a small ***early stop* so the problem never grows up.* "Fix what's about to break."
- 🔧 **Fix it when she sees it — Respond.** A problem is already here — find the **real gap** under it and build the fix. "Fix what's broken."

The Spark sequence (and your instinct) match: do **Foresight first**, **Respond as the capstone**. So this year she runs the loop 4 times — **two as Foresight**, **two as Respond** — and by Demo Day she can do both: get ready before the problem *and* solve it when it lands.

The two engines (run both, every week)

	Engine 1 — Daily Reps	Engine 2 — Build Expeditions
What	15-20 min/day on emeka-grades (math, reading, writing, daily, games)	One real project every ~4-6 weeks using the Spark 8-session loop
Job	Fluency & report-card standards — the "scales"	Meaning & agency — the "song"
Who drives	Emeka, solo (you check progress)	Emeka directs, you drive the typing
Proof	Streak + progress screen in the app	A live thing she gave to a real person

Engine 1 keeps the grades. Engine 2 keeps the **fire**. Most kids only get Engine 1. Emeka gets both.

Part A — The academic targets (advanced 3rd grade)

These are the 3rd-grade Common Core standards, pitched at the **top of the band** because she's G&T — but with a ★ **PRIORITY** flag on the three skills her report card said to grow. Each has a home in her app.

Math — "*from counting to reasoning*"

- **Multiplication & division within 100** — to **automatic recall** (not finger-counting). Times

tables 0-10 cold.

- **Fractions as numbers** – halves, thirds, fourths, eighths; fractions on a number line; equivalent

fractions ($\frac{1}{2} = \frac{2}{4}$); comparing fractions.

- ★ **PRIORITY – precision & strategy:** show the work, pick the right operation, *check* the answer.

Use the app's "what's happening / what do you know / what are you trying to find?" scaffold every time.

- **Multi-step word problems** (the G&T stretch): two operations in one problem, "does my answer make sense?"

- **Area & perimeter**, telling time to the minute, elapsed time, basic bar/picture graphs.
- *Enrichment:* simple patterns & "what's the rule?", intro to factors, friendly logic puzzles.
- **App home:** [Math](#) + [Daily](#) + [Games](#).

Reading – "from decoding to thinking about the text"

She *decodes* well – the gap is **comprehension**. The whole reading focus is understanding, not sounding-out.

- ★ **PRIORITY – comprehension:** after every read, a **retell** ("tell me what happened") + main idea.
- **Main idea + key details**, and **inference** ("how do you know? show me the words").
- **Lesson / moral / theme** of a story; character feelings & motives.
- **Asking and answering questions** using evidence from the text.
- *Enrichment:* compare two texts on the same topic; nonfiction text features (headings, captions);

"what is the author trying to make me think?"

- **App home:** [Reading](#).
- **Off-app target:** a **20-minute nightly read** + a one-sentence "what was the lesson?" out loud.

Writing – "from sentences to paragraphs"

She *can* write – the gaps are **adding detail** and **mechanics** (capitals, punctuation, commas).

- ★ **PRIORITY – detail + mechanics:** every draft gets one "add a detail" pass and one "fix the capitals/punctuation" pass. The app auto-checks both.

- **A full paragraph:** topic sentence → detail → detail → closing.
- **Dialogue** with quotation marks; **narrative** (beginning/middle/end) and **opinion** (claim +

reasons) writing.

- Capitals, end punctuation, commas in a series; spelling the grade word lists.
- *Enrichment:* revise her own draft ("make it stronger, not longer"), add one "showing" sentence.

- **App home:** Writing (it enforces min-sentences/min-words per grade).

The 4th strand — Thinking & Making (this is the Spark part)

Not on a report card, but the reason for the whole year:

- **Notice on purpose** (observation), **ask why**, **what-if**, **how-do-you-know**, ****what-would-change-my-mind**** — the 5-rung Thinking Ladder.
- Turning a noticing into a **build**, giving it to a real person, and **improving it from real use**.

Part B — The weekly rhythm

A repeatable week. Same shape every time; only the content changes.

Day	Engine 1 (daily reps, ~15–20 min)	Engine 2 (the build)
Mon	Math (app Math) + 20-min read	<i>Spark session</i> (see the loop below)
Tue	Reading (app Reading) + 20-min read	—
Wed	Writing (app Writing) + 20-min read	<i>Spark session</i>
Thu	Math + Daily mix + 20-min read	—
Fri	Games (fun reps) + "what was the lesson?"	Show-and-tell / log the week
Weekend	One free build, draw, or read-aloud together	rest / family pillar

Two non-negotiables (the fire):

1. **Callback** — every Spark session *starts* by making her retrieve last time's thinking.
2. **Open loop** — every Spark session *ends* with one real question she carries out the door.

Part C — The build expeditions (both methods, term by term)

Each expedition is **one real problem** → **one live tool she gives someone**, run across 8 short sessions. She'll do **4 across the year**, one per Pillar — **two in Foresight mode**, **two in Respond mode** — and each one *secretly* drills the academic skills from Part A. That's the trick.

The two loops (same rhythm, different starting question)

Both run on the same weekly rhythm; they only differ in *where the problem comes from*.

#	 FORESIGHT loop (<i>see it coming</i>)	 RESPOND loop (<i>fix what's here</i>)
1	Map it — how does this thing normally work?	Notice — a real problem she spotted

#	 FORESIGHT loop (<i>see it coming</i>)	 RESPOND loop (<i>fix what's here</i>)
2	Find the weak spot – where could it go wrong?	Listen – real quotes from the person who has it
3	Smoke before fire – what's the <i>early signal</i> ?	Find the Gap – the real problem under the obvious one
4	Play the tape forward – "if nobody acts, then...?"	Smallest Thing – first tiny version, critiqued
5	Smallest early stop – the tiniest thing that prevents it	Light It Up – a live tool, given to a real person
6	Build the stop – make the early-warning / helper live	Improve – a better v2 + proof it helped
7	Break your own fix – try to make it fail, then patch it	Second Star – a new or deeper build
8	Demo Day – shows what she caught <i>before</i> it broke	Demo Day – shows what she built + learned

Kid-language cheat: Foresight = "*smell the smoke and unplug it before there's a fire.*" Respond = "*the spill already happened – clean it up and stop it next time.*" Same noticing, different timing.

Term 1 (Fall) — **FORESIGHT** • **Pillar:** YOURSELF • **Academic focus:** Multiplication fluency + paragraph writing

Sample build: "*My Times-Table Smoke Detector*" – she figures out **which fact family she's about to forget** (the early signal), then builds a tiny daily early-warning practice that catches it *before* the test, not after a bad grade.

- **Play the tape:** "*If I don't catch this fact, what happens on the quiz?*"
- **Drills:** $\times/\div$ facts to automatic recall; she writes a **paragraph** explaining her early-warning system.
- **Real person:** herself (the easiest first "person" to practice Foresight on).

Term 2 (Winter) — **FORESIGHT** • **Pillar:** HOME • **Academic focus:** Fractions + multi-step problems

Sample build: "*Before-It's-a-Fight Fair Shares*" – she spots where an **unfair split is about to cause an argument** at home (snacks, chores, screen time) and builds a **fractions** helper that prevents the fight before it starts.

- **Smoke before fire:** the look on a sibling's face *before* the "that's not fair!"
- **Drills:** halves/thirds/fourths, equivalent fractions, "is this fair?" multi-step reasoning.
- **Real person:** the family. Proof = the argument that *never happened*.

Term 3 (Spring) — **RESPOND** • **Pillar:** COMMUNITY • **Academic focus:** Reading for main idea + opinion writing

Sample build: *"One Thing I'd Fix"* — a problem that's **already here**: she interviews a neighbor/classmate, finds the real gap, and writes a short **opinion piece** (claim + reasons) or a tiny info page that helps.

- **Drills:** main idea, inference, **opinion writing** with reasons and evidence.
- **Real person:** someone outside the family — the outward turn.

Term 4 (Summer/End) — ✨ RESPOND (capstone) • Pillar: WORLD • Academic focus: Research reading + narrative writing

Sample build: *"Something I Wonder About"* — she picks a real-world thing she cares about, reads two sources, and makes a little story or explainer that **teaches someone else** how to handle it.

- **Capstone twist:** she names whether her project is *Foresight or Respond* — and why. That naming *is* the proof she learned both.
- **Drills:** compare two texts, nonfiction features, **narrative** with dialogue.
- **Real person:** she *teaches it* to someone — the deepest test of understanding.

Part D — How we'll know it's working

Signal	Where to see it
Report-card standards holding/rising	School report card + app Progress screen
Math facts automatic	App streak + timed Games ; no finger-counting
Real reading comprehension	She can say the lesson of a book unprompted
Writing grows	Paragraphs get <i>stronger</i> , dialogue appears
The Spark part	She finishes & gives away 4 real builds this year
G&T track	Keep the report card strong → reapply / stay eligible

The Expedition Log: a real paper notebook. One line after every Spark session — *the problem I noticed, the realest thing they said, the smartest thing I thought*. By hand. This is the keepsake.

Coach's one job (restated, for you)

Run the rhythm. Protect the seed — **she decides**. Never let a session end without a question she carries out the door. Do that, and you haven't taught Emeka to do 3rd grade — you've taught her to **keep thinking, and to face outward**. That's the star that doesn't go out.

Quick-start (this week)

1. Open **emeka-grades.vercel.app**, set her profile to **3rd grade**, do the diagnostic.
2. Start the 20-min nightly read tonight; end with "*what was the lesson?*"
3. Run **Spark Session 1 — Notice** Monday: she finds one real "stuck moment" in her day.
4. Get her a notebook. Title page: "**Emeka's Expedition Log.**"